

ANALYZE THE PROBABILITY OF A FEARED EVENT

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Develop an awareness of the irrational nature of the fear and anxiety.
2. Examine the probability of the negative expectation occurring and its consequences.
3. Identify distorted self-talk that mediates the anxiety response.
4. Recognize that the feared outcome will not terminate the ability to function.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Dependency
- Depression
- Low Self-Esteem
- Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder (OCD)
- Phobia
- Social Discomfort
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Support the client as he/she takes the risk of looking boldly and fairly at the basis for his/her anxiety. Help the client to acknowledge the irrational basis for his/her anxiety and reinforce rational outcomes of feared situations that will not devastate his/her life. Pay special attention to the distorted cognitions that feed the fear and suggest realistic positive self-talk to counteract this strong mediation effect.

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Many of our fears grow in their intensity without us ever stopping to analyze their exact nature, their causes, their probabilities of occurrence, the amount of control we might have over the situation, and the very real outcomes that are possible if our fears were realized. This exercise will help you thoroughly review your fears. As you rationally analyze the nature and cause of your fear and its real outcome, the fear will dissipate and your ability to cope will increase. Take this step-by-step approach in looking at three of your greatest fears and then bring this analysis to your counselor for a thorough processing and reinforcement of coping skills.

1. My First Fear

A. What is the fear or anxiety about?

B. What is the possibility on a scale of 1 (very unlikely) to 10 (inevitable) that the feared outcome will actually happen? Circle one number.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

C. What self-talk messages do you give yourself that make the fear grow?

D. What are the very real consequences if the feared outcome did occur?

E. What can you do to control the outcome of the situation that you fear?

F. What is the worst possible real outcome if your fear was realized?

G. How would your life be affected if your feared outcome actually happened? How would you cope or continue to function?

2. My Second Fear

A. What is the fear or anxiety about?

B. What is the possibility on a scale of 1 (very unlikely) to 10 (inevitable) that the feared outcome will actually happen? Circle one number.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

C. What self-talk messages do you give yourself that make the fear grow?

D. What are the very real consequences if the feared outcome did occur?

E. What can you do to control the outcome of the situation that you fear?

F. What is the worst possible real outcome if your fear was realized?

G. How would your life be affected if your feared outcome actually happened? How would you cope or continue to function?

3. My Third Fear

A. What is the fear or anxiety about?

B. What is the possibility on a scale of 1 (very unlikely) to 10 (inevitable) that the feared outcome will actually happen? Circle one number.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

C. What self-talk messages do you give yourself that make the fear grow?

D. What are the very real consequences if the feared outcome did occur?

E. What can you do to control the outcome of the situation that you fear?

F. What is the worst possible real outcome if your fear was realized?

G. How would your life be affected if your feared outcome actually happened? How would you cope or continue to function?
